

# Sales Training Debrief — Session 16

## *Follow the Instructions. Build the Lego.*

Sales training led by Corie Dawson, Director · Tuesday 26 May 2026 · Marketing Sweet

### 1. The story — a Lego set with the kids

The session opened with a domestic scene. Three boys, a beautiful Lego set with four packets, and a deliberate decision to teach them how to follow a process. Four clear takeaway containers sat on the table — one for each packet — plus a fifth empty container as a staging tray.

The system was simple and explicit:

1. Open the instruction book to the current page. Read the list of parts required for the piece on that page.
2. Find each part in its packet. Pick and pack into the staging tray. Quantities exact.
3. Set the unused tubs aside. Focus entirely on constructing that one piece, with only the parts you've picked.
4. Once the piece is constructed, cross the page off in the book. Move to the next page. Repeat.

*"If you follow that process I've just given you at the start — what's the odds and probabilities of having the car on the box at the end?" "99.9%."*

That's the whole point of the analogy. With a real instruction book and a real process, the outcome is effectively guaranteed. The only way it doesn't get built is if someone decides to stop following the book.

### 2. The natural tendency — and why it kills the build

Kids' natural tendency is to go and go. Tip the packets into one pile, look at the picture on the box, start clicking pieces together based on what looks right. That works for the first ten minutes. By minute thirty, the build is wrong and nobody can untangle which piece came from where.

Adults do the exact same thing inside a sales role. The instruction book is on the desk. The process has been taught. Halfway through the build, the rep decides they're past the instructions — they know better, they can free-style this one. The result is identical to the Lego pile: a structure that looks nothing like the picture on the box, and no way to walk it back without starting over.

*"Then you build all the way up, and you realise it looks nothing like it did. Now you've got to unravel what was from the instructions and what was you — but you've crossed nothing off, so you can't tell anymore."*

### 3. Creativity time and instruction time are two different jobs

This is the distinction that has to land. Creativity is valuable — encouraged, even — but it has its own time and place. Sales execution is not that time and place. The job inside a pitch is execution against a known set of instructions, not invention.

| CREATIVITY TIME                                         | INSTRUCTION TIME                                               |
|---------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------|
| "What ideas have you got?"                              | "Follow step one. Then step two."                              |
| Open-ended. No right answer.                            | Closed. Right answer = the pattern that has worked before.     |
| Brainstorming. Designing the product. Naming the offer. | Pitching. Closing. Following the script. Running the playbook. |
| Permission to free-style.                               | Permission to free-style has been revoked. Build the thing.    |
| Mistakes here are part of the process.                  | Mistakes here are deviations from the process.                 |

*"When I ask you to be creative, I get nothing. When I ask you to follow instructions, I get creative. Don't get upset at me — these are choices."*

The job for the rep this week is to identify which mode they're in before they act. If the instruction book is open, the build is on. Free-styling is not bravery — it's the kid pouring all four packets into one pile.

### 4. The trap — "I'm a Lego master"

The specific failure mode that costs deals is the moment the rep decides they're past the instructions. Not at the start — they almost always start by trying to follow the process. The drift happens about a third of the way through, when the build feels familiar and the rep gets a flash of confidence.

The sequence is always the same:

- Step 1 — the rep starts following the process correctly. The opening lands.
- Step 2 — a few moves go well. The rep feels in control.
- Step 3 — the rep decides they can shortcut the next part. "I'm a Lego master." The instruction book gets pushed to the side.
- Step 4 — what gets built no longer matches the picture on the box.
- Step 5 — the rep can't tell which moves were from the instructions and which were improvised, because the cross-off step got skipped.
- Step 6 — the build collapses. The rep blames the instructions.

**THE RULE** Cross off every step. The cross-off isn't bureaucracy — it's the only way to know what's you and what's the system when something goes wrong.

## 5. The blame loop — when it goes wrong, the instructions get accused

When the build collapses, there are two possible explanations. One — the instructions were wrong. Two — the rep stopped following them. Inside the rep's head, the first explanation always sounds better.

*"When the build collapses, you say 'well, they were bad instructions.' On the other side, I'm saying — all I wanted was for you to get the jet hopper. I laid the instructions. Let's not pretend you were following them when you weren't."*

The cost of this loop is brutal. If the rep keeps blaming the instructions, the instructions keep getting ignored — and the cycle repeats every week. The only way out is to actually run the test.

## 6. The two-week test — settle it once

The simplest possible experiment to resolve the question. Pick a window — two weeks is enough — and run it as a clean test of the system. Whatever the coach says, do it. Don't add. Don't subtract. Don't get creative. Follow to the letter and watch what comes out the other end.

*"Give yourself two weeks of discipline. Whatever the coach says, follow it to the letter — and find out whether the system actually delivers what it promises. Run the test."*

Why the test works:

- It's time-boxed. No one's asking for a lifetime commitment — just a fortnight.
- It's falsifiable. If the system doesn't produce results, that's data. Discuss it after.
- It removes the ambiguity. Right now nobody knows if the system works or not, because nobody's actually run it cleanly.
- It protects the friendship. The rep stops arguing in the abstract about whether the coach is right and just runs the experiment.

## 7. Action items this week

5. Pick up the instruction book. Identify the current step of the process you're meant to be on. Stop drifting between steps.
6. Cross off each step as you complete it. The cross-off is the audit trail when something goes wrong.
7. Separate creativity time from instruction time. If the meeting is a pitch, the instructions are open. Free-styling is for design, not delivery.
8. Notice the drift moment — the third-of-the-way-in flash of confidence. That's the danger point, not the start of the build.
9. Run the two-week test. Pick the window, commit to following the playbook exactly, and review what changed at the end.
10. If the build collapses, ask first whether you followed the instructions — before reaching for "the instructions are wrong."

**THE ONE-LINER** Pick. Pack. Cross off. Build. Follow the instructions and the jet hopper builds itself. Free-style and the pile of bricks builds you.